

If you want to build, or invest — what should you back today?

Which categories, countries and business models are actually making money

Built on our own dataset: 1,000 businesses on TrustMRR, revenue verified through their Stripe, RevenueCat and Paddle accounts and frozen on 30 July 2026 — \$334m of lifetime revenue, \$13.5m of monthly recurring revenue, 262 of them currently for sale

*August'26
Strawman — for discussion only*



1,000

software and app businesses
with verified payment data

Executive Summary

Background

- Our dataset: 1,000 small software and app businesses on TrustMRR, revenue verified through their payment accounts, frozen 30-Jul-2026
- Two questions we set out to answer: if you are investing, what is worth buying; if you are building, what is worth 12 months of your life

1. What is happening

- Ten businesses out of a thousand make 61% of the money. The middle one makes \$282 a month
- The US is 26% of the businesses but 56% of the revenue. India has the third most builders and 1.2% of the revenue
- What separates winners is being found, not what they built: \$78 a month at zero domain authority, \$24.6k at DR 50+

2. Should we build, and in what

- AI is 27% of everything being built and 13% of the revenue. The middle AI business makes \$446 a month
- The money is in boring tools people use for work — Education, Analytics, Marketing, Content Creation earn 3-5x what AI does
- Selling to businesses pays 5.7x better than selling to consumers (\$1,036 vs \$181 a month) for the same build

3. What changed last month

- Only 43% of the live businesses grew last month. The normal outcome is not failure or success — it is flat
- Dev Tools is the only category where most businesses are growing (68%, +12%). Mobile apps and sales tools are shrinking
- How they take payment tells you what they are: Stripe = 87% of the revenue, RevenueCat = the phone-app world, newer providers = 12% of businesses and 1% of revenue

4. What to do

- Businesses for sale are priced at about 2.3x annual revenue whether they are growing or not — an opening for a patient buyer
- Five options for a builder and for an investor — illustrative, not mutually exclusive

A handful of businesses make most of the money — and most of the buyers are American

- **A thousand businesses, ten winners**

- Ten businesses hold 61% of the \$334m lifetime revenue; the biggest one (Stan) holds 23% by itself
- The middle business makes \$282 a month from 16 paying customers; 59% make under \$1,000
- 22% made nothing at all last month, even though the dataset is meant to show verified revenue
- So ignore averages here. The average is \$13.5k a month; the middle is \$282

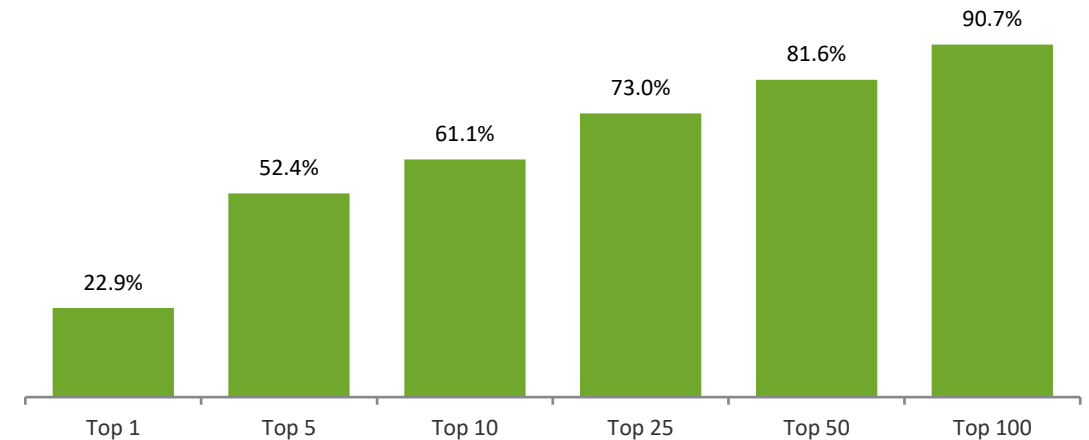
- **Built everywhere, paid for in America**

- US: 258 businesses but 56% of all monthly revenue, and a middle business at \$1,262 a month — people there pay
- India: 59 businesses, third most in the world, but \$157k a month in total (1.2%). The middle one bills \$6 a month
- France (79) and the UK (50) have more builders than their share of revenue; Canada and the Netherlands have the reverse
- So build in India but sell to the US in dollars. Nothing here supports selling at home first

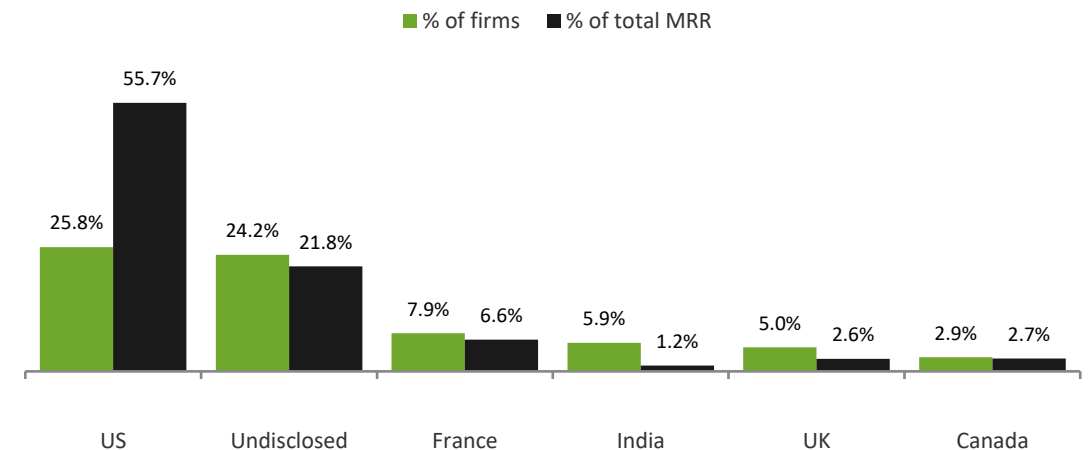
- **What actually drives the revenue**

- How well the site ranks on Google matters more than anything else we can measure (correlation 0.54)
- Monthly revenue by domain rating: \$78 at DR 0, \$274 at 1-10, \$1,036 at 11-30, \$4,727 at 31-50, \$24,618 above 50
- Twitter followers barely matter (0.15). An audience is nice; being found on search is what pays

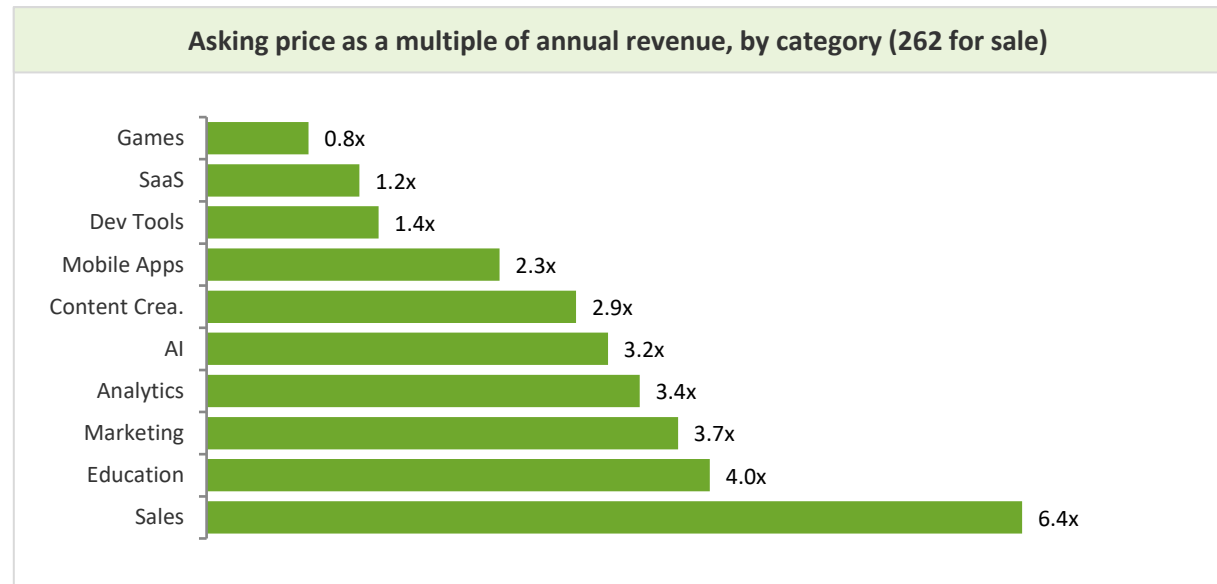
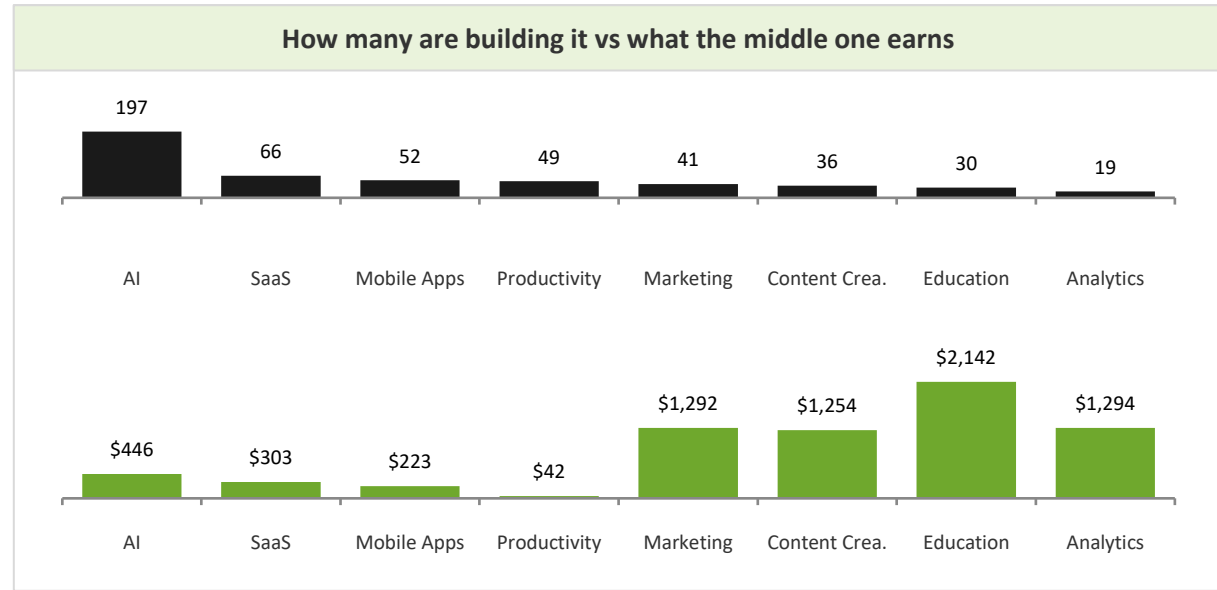
Share of all revenue held by the biggest businesses



Where they are built vs where the money comes from



Everyone is building AI — the money is in boring tools that businesses use for work



- Where everyone is building**

- AI is 197 businesses — 27% of everything built, 13% of the revenue. A third of them make under \$100 a month
- Inside AI the same pattern repeats: five businesses hold 56% of all AI revenue
- AI is cheap to build on top of, so everyone does. The crowd is the cost of entry

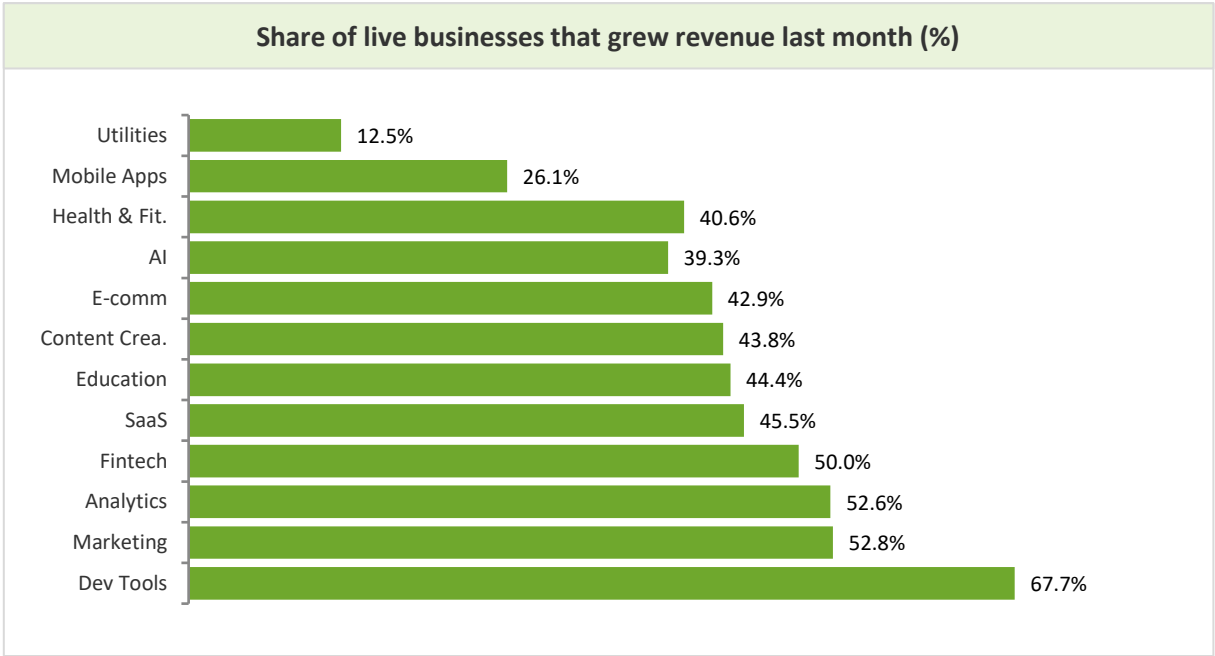
- Where the revenue actually is**

- Education (\$2,142), Analytics (\$1,294), Marketing (\$1,292), Content Creation (\$1,254) — three to five times what AI earns
- Selling to businesses: \$1,036 a month. Selling to consumers: \$181. Four in ten consumer apps make under \$100
- The dull categories that are hard to sell into have fewer entrants and pay better

- What buyers are paying for**

- 262 of the 1,000 are up for sale. The typical ask is \$35k, or 2.3x annual revenue
- AI asks 3.2x, but on tiny revenue — a good story attached to a small cheque
- SaaS (1.2x), Dev Tools (1.4x) and Games (0.8x) sell cheap — easy to copy, or heavy to maintain
- **Careful: the high multiples above come from only 4-11 listings each. Useful as a direction, not as a price**

Most businesses did not grow last month — dev tools are the exception



- **Flat is the normal outcome**
 - Of the 749 businesses still making money, only 43% grew last month. The middle one grew 0.0%
 - The realistic result of building one of these is not failure and not compounding growth. It is a few hundred dollars a month, holding steady
- **What is growing, what is shrinking**
 - Dev tools: 68% growing, up 12.4% in revenue and 9.5% in monthly revenue — the only category where most are growing
 - Phone apps (26% growing, down 3.1%) and sales tools (down 11.8%) are sliding — app stores are hard, and AI is eating sales tooling
 - **Careful: this is one month of a frozen file. It is a snapshot, not a trend**
- **How they take payment tells you what they are**
 - Stripe is where the money is. RevenueCat and Superwall are the phone-app world: many subscribers, small tickets, going backwards
 - The newer providers (Polar, Dodo, Creem, Lemon Squeezy) are 12% of businesses and 1% of revenue — they show intent, not demand
 - Useful screen: you can tell the model and the stage from the payment provider before reading a single number

How they take payment — businesses vs share of last month's revenue			
Stripe	636 firms	87% of revenue	Websites, business customers, the default
RevenueCat	189 firms	8% of revenue	72% consumer; 41 of the 52 phone apps
Superwall	17 firms	2% of revenue	Highest middle revenue of any provider: \$5,465
Polar / Dodo / Lemon Sq. / Creem	116 firms	~1% of revenue	What people start on, before revenue

What to do next — five options, for a builder and for an investor

#	Option	What the data says	What to check before acting
1	Buy the mispricing (investor)	Sellers ask about 2.3x annual revenue whether the business is growing or not — 2.4x for growing, 2.3x for flat. You are not paying for growth	Is it really mispriced, or does the price reflect founder dependence and churn you cannot see here? Who runs it after you buy it? 29% of listings earn under \$1k a year, so screening is most of the work
2	Underwrite distribution, not product (investor)	Search ranking explains more of the revenue gap than the category does (0.54 vs 0.15 for social following). Businesses above DR 50 earn 300x the ones at zero	Does ranking cause the revenue, or follow it? What it costs and how long it takes to rebuild. Whether AI search changes the value of ranking at all
3	Build B2B workflow, not AI wrappers (builder)	AI: 27% of builds, 13% of revenue, \$446 a month. Education, analytics and marketing earn three to five times that with far fewer entrants. Business customers pay 5.7x consumers	Do you know these buyers well enough to sell to them? Longer sales cycles and more support. Use AI inside the product, not as the product
4	Enter Dev Tools (builder)	The only category where most live businesses grew last month (68%, up 12%) — demand is growing faster than people are entering	Is this just the AI coding wave, and therefore temporary? Developers are famously hard to charge. One month of data — check it again on a fresh pull
5	Build in India, price in the US (builder)	India has the third most builders and 1.2% of the revenue; the US has 26% of the builders and 56% of the revenue. The gap is what customers will pay, not skill	How to reach US buyers with no US presence. Setting up payments and an entity. Covering US hours for support

How to read this: one frozen snapshot (30-Jul-2026) of businesses that chose to connect their payment account to TrustMRR, and for a quarter of them, chose to list themselves for sale — so the sample flatters itself twice. Category, country and customer type are self-reported and missing for a quarter of them. Prices are asked, not achieved.